the fertile alluvial plain lying between the Ganges and the Jumna. Three and a half millennia ago this became Aryavarta, the heartland of Arya culture, where two social groups – Brahmin priests and thinkers, and Kshatriya warriors and rulers – locked together in symbiotic alliance. This unique nexus gave Aryavarta-Bharat-Hind-India the stabilising continuity that made it possible for Mahatma Gandhi to speak in the 1920s of 'the beauty of the caste system', because, for him, it was caste that had saved Hindu India from disintegration: 'I believe that if Hindu society has been able to stand, it is because it is founded on the caste system.'[3]

In later years Gandhi's contacts with the Dalit social reformer Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar led him to modify what we would now consider to be his reactionary views. But Gandhi's point stands. That Brahmin–Kshatriya alliance was the *stambha*, the central column or backbone, around which Hindu society in the North revolved, even through what many would regard as the darkest days of Sultans Mahmud of Ghazni and Ala-ud-Din, Emperor Aurangzeb (who did more to sow division between his subjects than any of his Mughal predecessors) and Lord Lytton (who, as Viceroy, not only refused to implement available relief measures during the catastrophic Great Famine in South India in 1876-8, but ensured that record amounts of grain were exported to Britain at the same time).

But how much of this applied south of the Narmada River, to the Deccan and, in particular, to the deeper South and the country that many of its inhabitants would prefer to speak of as *Tamilakam*, 'the land of the Tamil people' (the ancient heartland corresponding to the present-day states of Kerala and Tamil Nadu but extending northwards to include Andhra Pradesh and Telangana as well as parts of Karnataka and Odisha)? The earliest recorded appearance of that word 'Tamil' can be seen on King Kharavela's